

ABANDONING ARMS
Naxals with their weapons after their surrender in Jagdalpur, Chhattisgarh, Oct. 17

FALL OF THE CADRES

Rise in surrenders, arrests and fatalities reflect weakening Naxal presence in Chhattisgarh

4,330
Naxals who have surrendered in the past seven years

3,896
Naxals who have been arrested

675
Naxals who have been killed in security operations

180
Security personnel who have been killed

Figures from 2019 to Dec. 3, 2025; Source: Chhattisgarh Police

In early 2024, a few months after the change of government in Chhattisgarh, the Union and state governments recalibrated their strategy to tackle Naxalism—once described by the late prime minister Manmohan Singh as India's biggest internal security challenge. Later that year, Union home minister Amit Shah announced a deadline of March 31, 2026, to bring Naxalism to a complete end in India. To get there, a tactical blitz was adopted initially: a series of security ops against 'red terror'. Bastar saw 123 operations in 2024, up from 69 in 2023. As many as 217 insurgents were killed, as against just 20 the previous year. It took a heavy toll and also reflected in the higher graph of Naxal deaths per operation in 2025. By the first week of December, 96 operations had already been carried out, 252 Naxals lay dead. Now it started looking like the endgame.

UNION HOME MINISTER AMIT SHAH SAYS THE NUMBER OF NAXAL-AFFECTED DISTRICTS IN INDIA HAS FALLEN FROM 126 IN 2014 TO 11 IN 2025 AND HIS DEADLINE TO END THE INSURGENCY BY MARCH 31, 2026, IS ON TRACK

The quality of strikes kept pace with the volumes. In 2025, the forces managed to neutralise several top Maoists, including Basavaraju, general secretary of the CPI (Maoist), and central committee (CC) members Korsa Dada and Raju Dada. The resulting leadership vacuum led to confusion among the cadres, and voices of dissent began to surface.

A mid-term review by the security establishment six months before the March 31 deadline made one thing clear. Battlefield success had come, driven by tech-based intelligence gizmos and superior weaponry. The gun had done its work, creating conditions conducive for ending Naxalism, but it would not finish the war on its own. Tactics now had to pivot to a new pillar: surrender. "We assessed around 1,200 active cadres in Bastar and 300 in inaccessible areas," says an SP of a Naxal-hit district. "It's not possible to engage all of them in operations and neutralise them, but to attain the objective, it was imperative to defang them, by getting leaders to surrender with their arms."

ENGINEERING THE EXITS

Officially, there has been no truce between the two sides. But October saw two of the biggest surrenders in the history of the insurgency. Politburo member Bhupathi, aka Sonu, laid down arms in Gadchiroli in the presence of Maharashtra chief minister Devendra Fadnavis, along with 60 comrades and 54 weapons. Two days later, CC member Rupesh, aka Satish—head of the north sub zonal committee of the Dandakaranya special zonal committee (DKSZC)—surrendered in Jagdalpur with 209 cadres and over 153 weapons in the presence of CM Vishnu Deo Sai. It's not just operations that have kept Bastar inspector general of police Sundarraj P. occupied. On November 25, 28 Naxals surrendered in Narayanpur in his presence. The next day, he was in Bijapur, facilitating the surrender of 41 more. On November 28, 10 Maoists—including Chaitu Dada of the Darbha division, believed to be among those involved in the eponymous massacre that killed top Congress leaders—gave up arms in Jagdalpur. On November 30, another 37 cadres followed in Dantewada.

How is this slew of surrenders being engineered? It began with the